

Sympathetic magic

Cunning folk employed many different strategies for their magic in the Renaissance. Some involved imbuing objects or animals with supposed powers based on symbolic links and correspondences—like for like. “Sympathetic magic” is a term used for an approach based on imitation and correspondence. For example, a liver disorder might be treated with a preparation made from an animal’s liver; or a treatment might be administered while telling a metaphorical story that was somehow linked to the condition being treated, as it was believed to focus the appropriate energy.

▼ A tale of transference

This painting by Florentine artist Paolo Uccello depicts the famous story of Christian hero St. George slaying a dragon, which often stood for evil. Destroying symbols of evil was a common form of sympathetic or transference magic.



◀ Witch bottle

People often blamed witches for their misfortunes. Some witch bottles contained pins to hurt the targeted witch, and they might also include an item belonging to the person said to be bewitched.

Seeking patterns to reflect greater forces in the universe was another sympathetic tool, one used in the popular practice of palmistry. Marks, lines, and shapes on the palm were used to read a person’s character and divine their future.

Countering evil

Counter forms of sympathetic magic were used to keep dark forces at bay—the practice of warding off evil is also called “apotropaic magic.” One tool

